# SCENE 003 — HARLAN

**Trigger:** All Scene 001/002 paths converge here **Time:** Pre-dawn to early dawn — sky going gray to pale gold **Location:** The field, edge of the dirt road **Incoming Flags:** HARLAN_FIRST_IMPRESSION (value set by Scene 001 choice)

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## CONDITIONAL OPENING — Based on HARLAN_FIRST_IMPRESSION

> *The value of this flag determines what Harlan sees when he finds Marcus.*

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**[CHOICE A — Called for Curtis]** You're still facing the tree line when the boots find you — slow, even, unhurried on dry grass. You turn. He stops twenty feet off. Old. White. Canvas jacket, lantern in one hand, walking stick in the other. He looks at the watch in your hand — or the empty space where it isn't — then at your face. He doesn't ask if you're alright.

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**[CHOICE B — Followed the Trail]** You're coming back out of the tree line when the lantern catches you. You stop. He stops. He lowers the light slightly — not the reaction of a surprised man. The reaction of a man confirming something. His eyes move from the tree line to your shirt to your hands to your face. Slow. Methodical. He already knows what's back there.

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**[CHOICE C — Found the Car]** You're near the road when he comes around the field's edge. He sees you and the car in the ditch at the same time. His eyes move between the two of you like he's deciding which is more interesting. Then he settles on you and stays there.

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**[CHOICE D — Tried to Remember]** You're still sitting in the grass when the lantern finds you. He stands at the field's edge a long moment without speaking. Just looking. When he finally moves toward you it's slow and deliberate — the walk of a man who wants you to have time to decide whether to run.

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**[CHOICE E — Stayed and Watched]** You've been watching each other across the field for ten minutes. He knew you were awake. You knew he knew. He finishes his walk without changing pace and stops five feet away. Looks down at you. Nods once — the nod of a man whose suspicion just became certainty.

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## THE PROBING — Harlan's Interview

He is old — seventy or older, the kind of age that gets hard to read past a point. A face like carved wood. Eyes pale gray and very still. He sets his lantern in the grass between you and leans on his walking stick, looking at you the way a man looks at a problem he's been expecting.

*"You're not from here,"* he says. Flat. Not a question.

He waits.

*"Passing through,"* you say, or don't say. Either way he nods like you confirmed something.

*"Where were you headed?"*

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**MARCUS RESPONSE 1 — Where were you headed?**

**Option A:** Tell him the truth — you had a delivery to make **Option B:** Keep it vague — just driving through **Option C:** Ask him who's asking before you answer anything **Option D:** Say nothing

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> *Harlan absorbs whatever Marcus gives him. His expression doesn't change. He glances at the trail in the grass, then back.*

*"You come off that road alone?"*

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**MARCUS RESPONSE 2 — Were you alone?**

**Option A:** Tell him about Curtis — your friend is missing **Option B:** Yes. Alone. **Option C:** Ask him what this is about **Option D:** Say nothing

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> *Here is where Harlan's probing sharpens. He's watching Marcus's eyes now. His breathing. The way Marcus holds himself.*

*"That blood on your shirt — where's it from?"*

A plain question. The plainest one. The one that matters.

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**MARCUS RESPONSE 3 — Where is the blood from?**

**Option A:** "I don't know. I woke up like this." **Option B:** "Something attacked us on the road." **Option C:** "That's my business." **Option D:** Say nothing — just look at him

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> *Harlan is quiet for a moment. He looks at Marcus's hands. Then at the tear in his shirt collar. Then at the trail. The lantern light moves between them in a small wind.*

*"You hurt anywhere?"*

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**MARCUS RESPONSE 4 — Are you hurt?**

**Option A:** "No. That's the thing — I'm not." **Option B:** "I'm fine." **Option C:** "Why do you keep asking me questions?" **Option D:** Turn the question back — "Are you?"

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## HARLAN'S CONCLUSION — Internal Assessment

> *This block is never shown to the player directly. It drives Harlan's behavior going forward.*

Harlan has been doing this long enough to know what he's looking at. The blood volume on Marcus's clothes — too much to be a minor wound. The complete absence of injury. The wide trail in the grass. The tree line. The timing.

He's seen this before. Not often. But enough.

The question is what Marcus is — victim, carrier, or something further along. And the question beneath that is whether Marcus knows. Based on the interview:

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**HARLAN RELATIONSHIP FLAG — Set based on response pattern:**

| Response Pattern | Flag Value | What Harlan Thinks |
|---|---|---|
| Honest across most responses | `HARLAN_REL: ASSET` | Cooperative, aware, potentially manageable. Worth monitoring closely before reporting. |
| Evasive but calm | `HARLAN_REL: UNKNOWN` | Hiding something but not hostile. Could go either way. Needs more observation. |
| Hostile or silent throughout | `HARLAN_REL: THREAT` | Uncooperative. Possible accelerated infection. Will escalate Dominion report. |
| Honest about Curtis specifically | `HARLAN_REL: ASSET+` | Gave up personal information voluntarily. Trusting. Harlan will use this — but also feels something close to reluctant sympathy. |

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## THE BRIEFING — Harlan Points the Way

> *Regardless of relationship flag, Harlan walks Marcus toward town. He won't go in — but he'll talk on the way there if Marcus lets him.*

He picks up his lantern and starts walking south toward the road without asking if Marcus is coming. Marcus follows or he doesn't. If he doesn't, Harlan stops after ten paces.

*"You're going to that town whether you want to or not,"* he says, back still turned. *"Unless you've got another option I can't see from here."*

He waits. Then walks again.

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**IF MARCUS WALKS WITH HIM — Harlan talks. Each piece of information requires Marcus to keep walking and not interrupt:**

*"Town's called Wroughtwood. Been here longer than most towns out this way deserve to be. People keep to themselves. Don't like strangers. Don't like questions. Don't like anything that upsets the way things run."*

He walks.

*"Man who runs things is named Calhoun. Aldous Calhoun. Owns the feed store, the mill, and about half the opinion in that town. What he decides about you in the first five minutes is going to matter more than anything else."*

He walks.

*"Sheriff's name is Pruitt. Ray Pruitt. He's not the worst man I've met but he's not going to go out of his way for you. He likes order. You become disorder, he'll treat you accordingly."*

He walks.

*"There's an inn on the main road. Woman named Hattie runs it. She'll give you a room and she won't ask more than she has to. You'll need money — she doesn't run charity."*

He walks.

*"South end of town, past the mill — blue house. Woman lives there alone. People in town don't go near her. You might want to."* He doesn't explain further. He never does.

He walks.

*"One more thing."* He stops. Doesn't look back. *"Whatever happened to you last night — and I'm not saying I know what that is — the people in that town have a word for it. Some of them have been waiting for it to come back. Not all of them will be glad to see it. Not all of them will be sorry either."*

He starts walking again.

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**IF MARCUS DOESN'T ENGAGE — Harlan says only:**

*"Inn's on the main road. Woman named Hattie. Sheriff's name is Pruitt. Watch yourself around a man named Calhoun."*

That's it. The rest Marcus will have to find on his own.

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## THE EDGE OF TOWN

The first buildings appear at the road's end. Harlan stops twenty feet short of the town sign. The lantern swings once and goes still.

He doesn't step past that point.

Marcus may notice this. He may not. Harlan doesn't acknowledge it.

*"I don't go in,"* he says, if asked. That's all he says about it.

The town sign is weathered wood, the name barely readable. Below it a newer plank, dark paint still holding:

*SUNDOWN TOWN. STRANGERS CLEAR OUT BY DARK.*

Harlan looks at Marcus one last time. His pale gray eyes move across him — the torn shirt, the dried blood, the state of him — and something in his face that isn't quite pity and isn't quite calculation settles somewhere between the two.

*"Walk in like you belong there,"* he says. *"Don't run. Don't apologize. Don't explain yourself to anyone who isn't asking."*

He turns and walks back the way he came without waiting to see if Marcus listened.

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## ENTERING WROUGHTWOOD — The Gauntlet

Marcus walks in alone.

The town is just waking. Smoke beginning to rise from chimneys. A dog barking somewhere and then stopping. The sound of a door. The smell of woodsmoke and frying fat and the particular quiet of a place that goes still when something new enters it.

A woman hanging laundry sees him first. Her hands stop moving. She watches him pass without a word.

Two men on the porch of the feed store — *Calhoun's,* the sign reads — stop talking. One of them leans forward in his chair.

A child stares from a doorway until someone pulls them back inside.

Marcus walks. Bloody shirt. Torn clothes. Nowhere to be and no explanation that would help him.

Then boots on the road behind him. Measured. Official.

*"Hey."*

One word. The kind that expects you to stop.

Marcus stops.

The man who walks around to face him wears a sheriff's badge that catches the morning light. Medium height, broad across the shoulders, somewhere in his forties. A face that has made a career of showing nothing. He looks Marcus up and down slowly — the blood, the torn collar, the state of him — and his expression doesn't change.

*"You want to tell me what happened to you?"*

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## PLAYER CHOICES — Sheriff Pruitt

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### A — "I was in an accident. My car's in a ditch back up the road."

**Stat Effect:** COMPOSURE — maintains **Pruitt Response:** He looks at Marcus a long time. *"What kind of accident does that to a shirt?"* He's not buying it entirely — but it's a story. Stories are manageable. *"Where you headed?"* This path keeps things civil but Pruitt is watching. **Flag Set:** PRUITT_SUSPICIOUS_LOW

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### B — Tell him the truth — you were attacked on the road

**Stat Effect:** HUMANITY +5 **Pruitt Response:** *"Attacked."* He repeats it flat. *"By what?"* Whatever Marcus says, Pruitt's eyes move briefly toward the tree line visible at the road's north end. Something passes across his face — recognition, maybe. Or dread. *"Anyone else out there?"* He asks about Curtis. Makes a note. Says he'll look into it. His tone says he already knows he won't find what Marcus is hoping for. **Flag Set:** PRUITT_TOLD_ABOUT_ATTACK, PRUITT_TOLD_ABOUT_CURTIS

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### C — "I'd rather not say."

**Stat Effect:** COMPOSURE -1, RAGE +5 **Pruitt Response:** A long silence. *"Son,"* he says, and the word has nothing warm in it, *"you are standing in my town covered in blood at sunrise. 'Rather not say' is not something I'm able to work with."* He doesn't touch Marcus. Not yet. But his hand moves to his belt without seeming to. *"Try again."* **Flag Set:** PRUITT_HOSTILE

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### D — Say nothing. Hold his eyes.

**Stat Effect:** RAGE +10 — something in the stare down feeds the wolf **Pruitt Response:** Pruitt goes very still. He's not used to being looked at like that. Something about it bothers him in a way he can't name. *"You got a name?"* he asks. Quieter now. Not softer — quieter. The difference matters. **Flag Set:** PRUITT_UNSETTLED — Pruitt will give Marcus slightly more space than he normally would, but for the wrong reasons.

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## SCENE NOTES

- **Harlan never lies.** Every deflection is technically true. He is a professional.
- **Harlan not entering town** is never explained in this scene. Observant players will log it. It becomes meaningful later.
- **"Some of them have been waiting for it to come back"** is the most important thing Harlan says. He is confirming the town has history with this — without telling Marcus what that history is.
- **Calhoun** is introduced by name only. He is the town's power center and will be a major force in Scene 004 onward.
- **Pruitt's reaction to the tree line** — that brief flicker — means he knows something. He has chosen not to know it formally.
- **RAGE +10 on the silent stare** is the first in-game moment where the wolf surfaces in a social situation. Marcus doesn't do anything — but something in how he holds himself changes and Pruitt feels it.

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## FLAGS SET / MODIFIED

| Flag | Condition |
|---|---|
| HARLAN_REL | Set based on response pattern during interview |
| HARLAN_TOLD_ABOUT_CURTIS | Response 2, Option A |
| HARLAN_WALKED_WITH | Marcus engages during the walk |
| SUNDOWN_SIGN_SEEN | All paths |
| PRUITT_NAME_KNOWN | All paths — Harlan mentions him |
| CALHOUN_NAME_KNOWN | Harlan engaged during walk |
| MARIE_MENTIONED_BY_HARLAN | Harlan engaged during walk |
| PRUITT_SUSPICIOUS_LOW | Scene end Choice A |
| PRUITT_TOLD_ABOUT_ATTACK | Scene end Choice B |
| PRUITT_TOLD_ABOUT_CURTIS | Scene end Choice B |
| PRUITT_HOSTILE | Scene end Choice C |
| PRUITT_UNSETTLED | Scene end Choice D |

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## LEADS TO

**SCENE 004 — PRUITT** The sheriff wants answers. Marcus is standing in the middle of Wroughtwood with blood on his shirt and no clean story. How this conversation ends determines whether Marcus walks free into town or starts his first day in a jail cell.